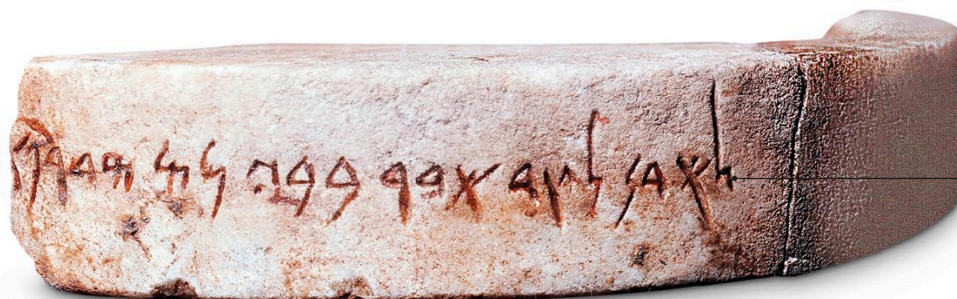


The first phonetic alphabet

- **What?** Written alphabet
- **Who?** Phoenicians
- **Where and when?** Mediterranean, c. 1500 BCE

The Phoenicians were traders of the ancient Mediterranean. They invented an alphabet—a writing system simpler than cuneiform or Egyptian hieroglyphs. The Phoenician alphabet had 22 characters, which were the first written symbols to record speech sounds rather than words.



Phoenician inscription on a cylindrical base, c. 600–500 BCE

Paper making

- **What?** First paper
- **Who?** Probably Ts'ai Lun
- **Where and when?** China, 105 CE

Before paper, people mainly wrote on materials such as wood, animal skins, or fabric. A Chinese court official called Ts'ai Lun is thought to have been the first to make paper. Using mashed plant fibers that were pressed and dried, he created a cheaper and lighter writing surface.

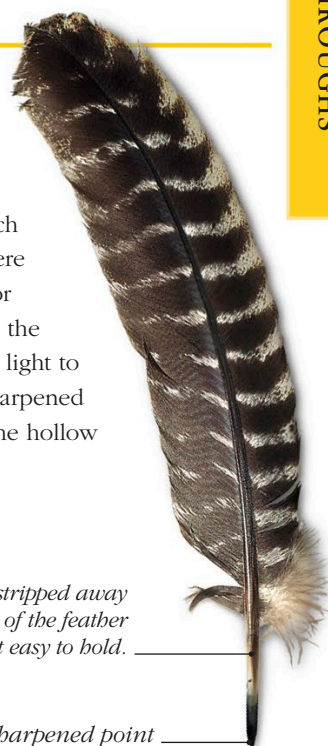


Early Chinese paper

Quill pen

- **What?** Writing tool
- **Who?** Unknown
- **Where and when?** Europe, c. 500 CE

The feathers of large birds such as the goose and the swan were used as writing implements for hundreds of years, right up to the early 20th century. They were light to hold, and the trimmed and sharpened quill tip made writing easy. The hollow feather shaft held the ink.



Most writers stripped away the lower part of the feather to make it easy to hold.

Sharpened point

Block printing

- **What?** First printing
- **Who?** Unknown
- **Where and when?** China, 600 CE

In block printing, the mirror images of the text and pictures are carved into a piece of wood. The wood is inked and pressed onto paper, which prints the page the right way round. This technique was first mainly used to print Buddhist texts, and eventually entire books were made this way.

Part of the *Diamond Sutra*, the earliest surviving printed book, produced in China in 868 CE

